THE MILK

Written by

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EXT. FARM -- DAWN -- ESTABLISHING

The morning sun creeps over the horizon of a sprawling DAIRY FARM.

The colors we are met with are so RICH and SATURATED that they appear unnatural.

A BRIGHT RED, picturesque barn. Pristine white fences.

Plump Holstein cows graze on the fresh spring grass in the paddocks.

Birdsong. Soft wind. Everything is perfect.

INT. BARN -- DAWN

A single HOLSTEIN COW stands calmly in her stall, chowing down on a bucket of GRAIN.

THE FARMER (20s-50s) approaches with a cloth and a bucket of water.

We watch over the shoulder as the Farmer cleans off the cow's udder. They whistle as they work; they've done this thousands of times.

The Farmer reaches for a MILKER - four suction cups connected to clear tubes.

CLOSE ON: The Farmer attaches the machine to the cow's udder.

The machine turns on. We hear the PULSING of the VACUUM PUMP.

MILK streams down the clear tubes.

INT. BARN -- MILK ROOM -- DAWN

We are in a sterile milk room.

A large, BULK TANK takes up the whole of it. A giant, refrigerated steel vat. Milk flows into it through pipes from the milking parlor.

The liquid is bright white, almost GLOWING under the fluorescent lights.

The Farmer opens a VALVE at the bottom of the tank.

CLOSE ON: Milk loudly streams from the nozzle into a large, STEEL CONTAINER below.

INT. FARMHOUSE -- KITCHEN -- MORNING

Milk is poured from the STEEL CONTAINER into clean GLASS BOTTLES lined up on a kitchen island. Caps twisted tight.

A PINK LABEL is then stuck onto each bottle: a cartoon, SMILING COW.

The bottles are placed into WIRE BASKETS.

One is set aside.

EXT. FARMHOUSE PORCH -- MORNING

CLOSE: The Farmer sits in a ROCKING CHAIR. They sigh.

Their hands tremble a bit as they take a sip from a GLASS MILK BOTTLE.

Instantly, their shoulders lower and their breath steadies.

Their world just got more colorful - only SLIGHTLY - we only notice if we pay very close attention.

We pull back as they lean back in the chair and look out over their land. They are living life straight out of *Farmer's Magazine*. Again, everything is perfect.

EXT. SUBURBAN CUL-DE-SAC -- DAY

We've gone from *Farmer's Magazine* to *Suburban Life*.

The warm, sunny neighborhood is pristine. Cookie-cutter houses and perfectly kept lawns.

A JOGGER runs down the street. She wears a TRACKSUIT as PINK as the labels on the milk bottles.

We follow her closely until she passes a MILK TRUCK.

The Farmer steps out of the truck, carrying one of the wire baskets full of milk.

We track behind them as they walk down the sidewalk, up to the FRONT DOOR of a house.

CLOSE ON their HAND. They ring the doorbell.

We watch their back as they stand perfectly still in front of the door for a few beats.

The door opens, and the HOMEOWNER is out of our view, obscured by the Farmer's body.

CLOSE ON the Farmer's mouth as they SMILE, warm and bright, with perfect teeth.

Returning to the back shot, the Farmer removes one of the milk bottles from the basket, and passes it to the obscured homeowner.

EXT. SUBURBAN CUL-DE-SAC - DAY -- MONTAGE

The Farmer moves from house to house.

Doors open and DIFFERENT HANDS accept milk bottles.

One door does not open. The Farmer places a bottle on the WELCOME MAT.

They walk back to the truck with an empty wire basket.

They pass the Jogger from earlier. She stands on her porch, drinking the milk directly from the bottle.

She smiles brightly at the Farmer and WAVES. They WAVE back.

Everything is perfect.

EXT. FARMHOUSE PORCH -- AFTERNOON

The Farmer sits in their ROCKING CHAIR again. They read the newspaper.

We notice as they read, their expression shifts to slight CONFUSION, but quickly shakes it off. They set the newspaper aside on a table, and take a sip of the milk from a glass.

We hear sounds of an ENGINE and TIRES ON GRAVEL. The Farmer perks up, looking out.

Coming up the DRIVEWAY, stirring up dust in the golden afternoon light, is a small CAR.

The car pulls to a stop in front of the porch. Dust settles.

A figure exits the car: THE GUEST (20s-40s). They wear rumpled clothes, and have dark circles under their eyes. They look exhausted. Worn down, for some reason...

The Farmer sets down their glass and stands. They smile at the Guest; the perfect image of serenity.

The Guest looks toward them. They move toward the porch, slowly at first, then quickly as they get closer to the Farmer.

The Farmer meets them at the porch steps. They EMBRACE.

They are clearly very familiar with one another. The Guest looks RELIEVED to be here. They tremble in the hug, while the Farmer holds them calmly.

INT. FARMHOUSE -- KITCHEN -- EVENING

GOLDEN HOUR SUNLIGHT streams through the lace curtains of the farmhouse. But despite the beauty, the world is a bit more GREY than we've gotten used to. We are seeing from the GUEST'S PERSPECTIVE now. It's depressing.

A simple but beautiful meal is spread across the table: roasted chicken, vegetables, fresh bread.

The Farmer and Guest sit across from each other. They eat in silence.

The Guest takes a bite of the food. They try to smile, but still look painfully sad.

The Farmer stands, moves off screen.

They return with a glass bottle of milk. They set it in front of the Guest.

The Guest looks down at it.

CLOSE ON: The pink label. The smiling cow.

The Guest looks up at the Farmer. They nod, encouraging, with a gentle smile still plastered on their face.

The Guest picks up the bottle and drinks from it.

CLOSE ON: Their throat as they swallow.

Their eyes widen. Their shoulders relax.

Once again, the world around them becomes MORE SATURATED.

The Guest LAUGHS, genuine and surprised. They look at the Farmer with wonder.

The Farmer smiles.

EXT. FARM -- SUNSET

The two walk the property together, bathed in the perfect golden sunset. The farm seems even more beautiful in this light.

The Guest looks as though they are seeing the world for the very first time. They run their hand along the white fence. Everything is so beautiful.

They come to an open field and watch the sunset.

The Farmer, instead, watches THEM take in the beauty. They've seen the sunset enough times.

CLOSE ON: The Guest brushes the Farmer's hand with theirs. The Farmer grabs their hand, their fingers intertwine.

INT. FARMHOUSE - BEDROOM -- MORNING

The Guest WAKES in the Farmer's bed, late enough for sunlight to be filling the bedroom. They blink, disoriented.

They reach across the bed. Empty. They are alone.

They sit up, pulling the sheet around themself. They still appear calm, but less happy than the previous night. The spell is wearing off, a bit.

They listen. We hear the faint SIZZLE of something cooking downstairs. Clinking of dishes.

INT. FARMHOUSE -- STAIRCASE -- MORNING

The Guest descends the stairs, wearing their clothes from the previous day.

INT. FARMHOUSE -- KITCHEN -- CONTINUOUS

The Farmer stands at the stove, their back to the Guest. They are humming softly.

The Guest pauses in the doorway, watching them.

The Farmer turns, sees them. Their face lights up.

They gesture the table; the Guest's plate is already set. Eggs, bacon, toast.

And, of course, two glass bottles of milk.

INT. FARMHOUSE -- KITCHEN -- MORNING

They eat. The Guest picks at their food, eating none of it. They are returning to the state in which they arrived.

CLOSE ON: The milk bottle in front of them. Untouched.

The Farmer glances at it. Back to the Guest's face.

They reach across the table and push the bottle closer to them, encouraging.

The Guest just stares at it. Then looks at the Farmer.

GUEST
(quietly)
I--

They pause, speaking feels odd. This is a nod to the fact that this is our first line of dialogue. How strange.

GUEST (CONT'D)
I should probably get going...

The Farmer's smile slightly drops. They are still perfectly content, but concerned now.

FARMER
Stay for breakfast. You'll feel better.

GUEST
I am. I just... I shouldn't be-- I should be trying to-- Uh--

A beat. They shake their head, confused. They don't remember what they "should be" trying to do... But it was something important, surely.

GUEST (CONT'D)
I'm just gonna use the restroom.

The Guest gives a half smile. The Farmer nods, still so calm.

They stand, we follow them down the HALLWAY, toward the bathroom.

INT. FARMHOUSE -- HALLWAY -- CONTINUOUS

The Guest glances back, the Farmer still sits at the table, drinking their milk. They face away from the Guest.

They open the bathroom door.

INT. FARMHOUSE -- BATHROOM -- CONTINUOUS

The Guest closes the door softly. They stand still, mulling something over.

Something is eating at them, but they don't know what is wrong. This shows on their face.

They look at their reflection in the mirror. The bags are heavy under their eyes, and we now notice a few small cuts on their face. They weren't there until just now.

They shake their head again.

They turn off the FAUCET, making the water run loudly.

Then, quietly, they open the bathroom door a crack.

INT. FARMHOUSE -- HALLWAY -- CONTINUOUS

The Guest peers out. The kitchen is around the corner, out of sight. The Farmer can be heard moving around, humming again.

The Guest slips out of the bathroom, leaving the faucet running.

They sneak, quickly, toward the front of the house.

As they near the FRONT DOOR, their foot hits a particularly SQUEAKY BOARD. They freeze.

The humming stops.

The Guest reaches for the door handle. They glance back one more time - nothing. They turn the handle and open the door.

EXT. FARMHOUSE PORCH -- CONTINUOUS

The Guest steps out onto the porch. Behind them, running water from the bathroom can still be heard, faintly.

They close the door, then SPRINT down the steps, to their car.

EXT. FARM -- CONTINUOUS

The Guest stops after opening their car door. They hesitate, then look toward the farmhouse.

It sits peaceful and still. No one in the windows, nor at the door. They get in their car.

INT. GUEST’S CAR -- CONTINUOUS

The Guest fumbles with their keys, then starts their car.

They throw it in reverse and hit the gas hard.

EXT. FARM -- CONTINUOUS

POV from the FRONT PORCH: The car backs up quickly, then spins around, pulling down the driveway.

INT. GUEST'S CAR -- CONTINUOUS

The Guest’s eyes dart to the REARVIEW MIRROR.

The Farmer stands in the open doorway of the house, watching them with a smile still plastered on their face.

The Guest looks back at the drive ahead. Then, just ONE MORE look in the rearview and--

They SLAM on the brakes.

EXT. FARM -- MORNING -- SERIES OF SHOTS

The oversaturated, technicolor world we’ve horribly grown used to is now long gone. We’re now living in taupe.

The red barn is FADED, PEELING. The white fences are BROKEN, ROTTING. The perfect blue sky is GREY, HAZY.

The Guest’s car sits idle in the driveway.

INT. GUEST'S CAR -- CONTINUOUS

The Guest looks down at their hands on the steering wheel. They are DIRTY. Their clothes are STAINED and TORN. They touch their face, the cuts are now accompanied by BRUISES.

Beat.

They press the gas, and drive forward, in shock.

INT/EXT. GUEST’S CAR -- SUBURBAN CUL-DE-SAC -- MORNING

THROUGH THE WINDSHIELD: We watch the horrified face of the Guest as they drive through a landscape of decay.

Behind them, the same cookie-cutter houses we once knew on this street are now RUN-DOWN. The lawns are either dead or overgrown with weeds.

On the porch of one house sits a MAN. He rocks back and forth, muttering to himself. His hands clench an EMPTY MILK BOTTLE.

They do not stop driving.

The JOGGER from before STUMBLES down the street. No longer in a pink tracksuit but in RAGS. She stops, looks at the car with ANTICIPATION. She was hoping it was the Farmer...

A MAN crawls out from a ditch, toward the car.

A WOMAN stands in her overgrown yard, staring vacantly at the Guest as they drive by.

They all are just WAITING.

The guest soon PULLS OVER. Their breathing is ragged. Tears stream down their face.

They lower their head down to the steering wheel, before hearing the sound of SHATTERING GLASS. They look up.

EXT. SUBURBAN CUL-DE-SAC -- MORNING

A figure in the distance SMASHES a car window and reaches inside, looking for something.

INT. GUEST'S CAR -- CONTINUOUS

The Guest watches. They stare, dead-faced at the near-apocalyptic world around them.

They close their eyes for a long beat. Open them. Nothing has changed.

EXT. GUEST’S CAR -- TIME LAPSE

We watch THROUGH THE REAR WINDSHIELD of the Guest’s car, idling on the dilapidated street.

The light changes around them as hours pass.

As the night rolls in, THE TIME LAPSE ENDS when a PERSON comes up and bangs on the window.